

DVD

Divided

DVD writers are going to define the future of storage. But is the confusion with standards going to get in the way?

In less than 50 years, drastic improvements have been made in the area of storage. Perhaps not drastic but radical, for today information flows smoothly in gigabytes across computers and networks. Thanks to space-hogging applications, music, movies, and immense data, today we are embarrassed to own up a 10 GB hard drive in a conversation. Enough just isn't enough anymore.

The most popular means to store data outside the hard disk is still the trusty old CD-ROM, which is packed with all of 650 MB of storage space. However, technology is relative—what's good enough for me might not be good enough for you. Yet, we are all users of technology, sharers, an audience that spends countless waking hours in front of computers. And in spite of the apparent information overload, we have learned to gather what's best from the digital jungle. So one thing becomes clear: the need for a safer place to store all that information. As the digital world turns its audience hungrier for information, data sees itself spilling over to a totally different format—a format which is more versatile than the CD-ROM and which stores much more. Enter DVD, with all its versatility and definitions.

Sure, DVD in itself isn't exactly new. Actually, the word DVD doesn't correlate to something tangible. Instead, it is a term representing a set of industry standards that describe how data is accessed and alternatively, how data is written onto a particular medium. In the case of DVD, the medium is the Digital Versatile Disk.

The store age

The fact that you may currently have at least 650 MB of digital canvas at your fingertips is great,

but quite honestly, storage isn't what it used to be. Anyone who's been compelled to back up their data on CD stacks that reach the roof knows what we're talking about. Not to mention the pain of managing such a collection.

When the CD-Writer made its debut in 1997, it seemed as though the entire world could be backed up on just a couple of discs. A 2.1 GB hard disk was considered spacious by anyone's standard and aside from the prohibitive cost of CD-Writers at that time, 650 MB really made a lot of sense.

But now with hard drives going beyond the 100 GB barrier, not only does a 40 GB drive look like an old timer, but the backup solution, the CD-Writer, begins to show its wrinkles too. While CD-RW media delivers a standard 650 MB of storage space, some discs push it to 800 MB. A DVD disc holds a payload of 4.7 GB on a single side. If you have a double DVD media, it can dispense a peak of 9.4 GB! That's over 14 times the capacity of regular CD-R media. Do things sound better now?

CD-RW is expected to dominate the consumer removable storage market for at least three years before it finally runs out of steam, yielding to the much more promising DVD format. We can only guess what's going to happen to all those 20x CD burners in all those houses in all those places!

It's all a mosh pit

Though moving towards DVD as a storage medium seems inevitable, consumers are faced with a standards problem. Just as CD-R and CD-RW have become synonymous with CD-based storage, DVD too has its own

DVD is the next wave in storage—if it can overcome its identity crisis